

YOUR QUESTIONS, ANSWERED

Nick Foley takes the floor

Nick Foley · [Longcloud](#) · Whanganui farm kid turned AI & software developer

You threw some cracking questions at Nick on the night. Here are his answers, in his own words: practical, no hype, and grounded in actually building this stuff in Aotearoa.

1 With sensitive freight, communication needs to be secure. How does AI assist in creating or supporting secure communication?

Good question, and the honest first answer is that AI doesn't replace the boring fundamentals: encryption, access controls, and people who don't click dodgy links. That's your fence and your gate, and no clever tool fixes a gate someone's left open. Where AI genuinely helps is around the edges: spotting phishing and dodgy attachments before anyone opens them, flagging when sensitive info is about to go to the wrong place, redacting details automatically, and keeping an eye on your logs for odd behaviour. Think of it as a very alert farm dog. It doesn't build the fence, but it barks early. Get the basics right first, then let AI watch your back.

2 What is the safest AI tool for a start-up's business planning, from a privacy and legal perspective?

There's no single "safest" tool; there's a safe way to set one up. The thing that matters most is the plan you're on. Business and enterprise tiers (Claude, ChatGPT Enterprise, Copilot inside your own Microsoft tenant) are built so your data isn't used to train the models, and you get a proper data-processing agreement. The free consumer versions are where people get burned. So pick a reputable provider, get on a paid business tier, read the terms once (or get someone to), and keep your genuinely sensitive legal material with your actual lawyer. The tool is only ever as private as the account you run it through.

3 My workplace is run by a Luddite who has banned all use of AI and rejected every suggestion of governance, guardrails or pilots. Any advice?

First up, don't go rogue with company data to prove a point. That's how you become the cautionary tale. Second, the fear is usually coming from somewhere real: data leaks, quality, or people's jobs. Meet that head-on instead of arguing the tech. Don't try to sell "AI"; find one small, low-risk, boring job it does well and show a result, not a slide deck. Speak his language: time saved, risk reduced, money. And pick your battles, honestly. Sometimes you plant the seed, do great work, and wait for the ground to thaw. If it never does, that tells you something too.

4 For a junior data engineer role, which AI skills are essential for candidates?

The unglamorous truth: get the fundamentals rock solid first. SQL, Python, how data actually moves through a pipeline, and how to model it. AI doesn't paper over gaps there, it just makes confident mistakes faster. On top of that I'd want someone who can use AI as a copilot without switching their brain off: prompt it well, read the code it hands back, and know when it's wrong. A working understanding of the LLM side helps too, embeddings, retrieval, calling APIs, and above all keeping data clean, because rubbish in is still rubbish out. The real skill is judgment. The tools change every six months; judgment doesn't.

5 What did you use to make the video game, and could my 12-year-old do that with no AI experience? #schoolholidays

Love this, do it. For a 12-year-old with zero experience, start with something built for the job: Scratch is brilliant and free, and they'll have something playable in an afternoon. From there, Godot or a bit of Python with an AI assistant helping write the code is a great next step. For mine, I leaned on AI heavily to do the grunt-work coding while I steered, which is honestly the same way your kid can learn now: describe what you want, let the AI draft it, then work out why it broke. That last bit, the fixing, is where the real learning happens. Best school-holiday project going. Happy to point you at a couple of links.

6

Will AI outsmart human beings one day?

Depends what you mean by “smart”. At narrow things it already runs rings around us; it'll beat you at chess and churn through code faster than any human alive. But that's not the same as wisdom, or judgment, or knowing what actually matters to people. The GPS in the tractor is better than me at driving a dead-straight line, but it isn't deciding what to plant, or why. That's the bit I care about. My whole talk was about exactly this: the point isn't machines out-thinking us, it's us staying connected and human while we use them. Don't fear it, don't worship it, and keep a person in the driver's seat.

7

What would you recommend to the public sector about how fast they should implement AI?

Deliberately, not recklessly, and the order matters. The public sector carries a duty most businesses don't: fairness, privacy, and being accountable to everyone, not just customers. So move quickly on the low-stakes back-office stuff, drafting, summarising, cutting admin, because that frees people up and builds confidence. Move slowly and carefully anywhere a decision affects someone's rights, money, or access to a service, and never hand those fully to a machine without a human accountable for the outcome. Strong governance, real pilots, and be honest with the public about where and how you're using it. Trust is the whole currency there, and it's hard-won and easily lost.

8

When will new businesses start implementing agents and AI instead of traditional ERP systems?

It's already starting, but I'd be careful reading it as “agents replace the ERP”. You still need a solid system of record, one source of truth for your money, stock and customers, and that's what an ERP is. What's changing is that new businesses are building lighter: a few good tools stitched together with agents doing the workflow on top, instead of one giant system running the whole show. So for now, think agents around and on top of your core systems, automating the busywork, rather than instead of them. The heavier the compliance and the money involved, the longer you'll want that dependable source of truth sitting underneath.